

Q I have more than one person in mind as a birth partner. Am I allowed to have two?

Some hospitals will allow two birth partners to be present in the delivery room with you (you may be able to have more, as long as none of them interferes with the medical staff). Talk to both of your potential birth partners and make sure they each understand that the other will be there. Check, in particular, that your partner is happy about the arrangement—this is an intimate occasion and he or she may feel strongly that it's something that needs to happen only between the two of you. It can be good to assign roles to each person attending—perhaps you can ask one birth partner to be there to support you emotionally, while the other one takes a more practical role, ensuring you have well-plumped pillows and creating the right ambience in the room for you. Be clear about whom, if anyone, you want to be at the birthing end of the event. The last thing you want is for each of them to start jostling to get the best view.

Q Can I have my older children present at my home birth?

Talk to your midwife in advance of your labor and establish what the rules are for accommodating other children. If your older children are with you, it's a good idea to assign someone else to take care of them for snacks and general entertainment (remember, labor can be a long process). That person may be your partner or another adult who has come to help. Your children shouldn't be a distraction for you or source of worry. They shouldn't get in the way or interfere with the procedure. Also, consider your children's ages and personalities and whether or not you think they will be able to cope with seeing their mom go through labor and birth. Even an easy birth can be traumatic for young children to witness. Talk through with them what's going to happen, and tell them that giving birth hurts the mommy, but it's safe pain and goes away as soon as the baby is born. Use words suitable for your children's level of understanding and encourage lots of questions. If you decide, on reflection, that it might be too much for them, ask a close friend or a grandparent to occupy them nearby (in the yard

Q Is the baby's dad less likely to bond with the baby in the long term if he isn't at the birth?

Studies show that his presence at the birth doesn't make a difference to a dad's ability to bond with his baby.

As long as he is fully engaged in the newborn's care once he or she has arrived in the world, a dad will definitely bond with his baby in the long term. Bonding is an intense attachment between parents and their baby. Bonding with a baby takes time and is a process that takes place as a mom or dad gets to know and takes care of their newborn baby. It gives parents the desire to nurture and take care of a baby. The only measurable difference is that fathers who are present at the birth tend to be more confident handling the baby; fathers who feel really positive about watching the birth tend to be more willing to take care of the baby independently of the mother (which gives you the opportunity to have a break every now and then).



Doting dad Make sure dad is just as involved as you with diaper changing and outfit changes from the start. Also, encourage him to have skin-to-skin contact and make sure he gets to hold your new bundle of joy.

if it's nice weather or in another room in your home) and invite them in only once (even as soon as) the baby has been born. It will be an unforgettable experience for everyone involved.

Q My partner doesn't think he'll be able to deal with seeing me in pain during labor. What can be done to help?

Many men confess that the hardest part of being with their partners as they give birth is seeing them go through pain and feeling helpless to do anything about it. The person you have with you during labor and birth needs to be calm, composed, and authoritative (with you and perhaps with the hospital staff); sometimes making decisions for you based on your birth plan. If your partner thinks he's likely to panic or faint, perhaps he may indeed be better waiting outside the delivery room until after your baby is born. You have several options:

» **Separate birth partner** Choose someone whom you trust entirely as a birth partner and who can support you fully to stay in the delivery room from start to finish, calling your partner in only when the baby is born.

» **The early part** Have your partner in the room with you, but have someone else available to come in as soon as your partner finds it's getting too much for him to be present.

» **Time limit** Ask your partner to stay with you for as long as he can stand it, and then to step out and let the hospital's labor nurses support you until the baby is born.

» **Stay throughout** Ask your partner to stay the whole time, but tell him that it's fine if he stays at your head end (in which case it's unlikely that he'll see anything too gory) and turns away if he wants to during any stressful moments. Practice breathing techniques together so that you can both use them to relax during labor—for you to cope with the pain, and for him to cope with you being in pain.